MEMO · EVANSTON VOTER POLL

What Evanston voters think of D65's budget plan

Public Policy Polling · 665 Evanston voters · Nov. 4–5, 2026

> Evanston voters oppose District 65's budget plan by more than 3 to 1. Two-thirds want the board to delay closing schools until it has a long-term plan.

Voters want the board to slow down

- **65% oppose the plan; 21% support it.** Opposition outweighs support in every group the poll measured, including D65 parents (78% oppose), homeowners (64%) and voters over 65 (53%).
- **66% want the board to delay closing schools** until it has a fuller long-term plan for finances and academics. 19% want it to move ahead now.
- **This is not just parents.** 78% of respondents have no child in a D65 school. They oppose the plan 62% to 23%, and want the board to delay closing schools 62% to 20%.

Closing schools undercuts the 2028 referendum

District 65 says the cuts buy time to ask voters to raise taxes in a 2028 referendum. That referendum already trails, 28% for to 41% against, and 47% of voters say local property taxes are already too high (38% are willing to pay more to support local schools). Closing Dewey and Lincolnwood would make 41% of voters less likely to support a referendum and only 11% more likely.

Trust is the obstacle

	POSITIVE	NEGATIVE
Trust D65 to manage taxpayer money	22%	**65%**
Confidence in the school board	25%	**64%**
Schools headed in the right direction	10%	**62%**
District listened to community input	24%	**53%**

What would build support

A long-term financial plan with clear spending limits was voters' top choice for earning their referendum support (38%), twice the next option, an independent citizen committee overseeing spending (18%). Voters' top priority for the board is improving academic achievement (33%), then keeping neighborhood schools open (24%); balancing the budget is third (19%).

Bottom line: Voters are not asking the board to ignore the deficit. They want a fuller long-term plan before schools close. Closing them first costs the support the district's own plan depends on.

Why these results are reliable. Respondents were selected at random from Evanston's registered voters, not self-selected, and the results are weighted to reflect the city's electorate. With 665 respondents, the margin of error is ±3.8 points, far smaller than the gaps reported here.

Public Policy Polling surveyed 665 registered voters in Evanston, Nov. 4–5, 2026, by text (95%) and landline (5%). Full results, crosstabs, and question wording are available.